

Joint Pain: Single Joint

(Monoarticular Joint Pain)

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Pain that is isolated to just one joint is called monoarticular joint pain. A joint may simply be painful (arthralgia) or may also be inflamed (arthritis).

Pain in a single joint may be caused by arthritis. Arthritis usually also causes warmth and swelling, and rarely redness of the overlying skin. Pain may occur only when the joint is moved or also be present at rest. Fluid may collect within the joint (called an effusion).

Pain that seems to be coming from a joint sometimes originates in a structure outside of the joint, such as a ligament, tendon, or muscle (see [Introduction to the Biology of the Musculoskeletal System](#)). Examples of such disorders are [bursitis](#), [tendinitis](#), [sprains](#), and strains. Pains caused by these disorders are usually not considered true joint pains.

Causes of Pain in a Single Joint

Common causes of pain in a single joint include [infectious arthritis](#), [gout](#) and related disorders, and [osteoarthritis](#). Joint pain may be the first symptom of a disorder that affects other organs in the body, such as a [systemic rheumatic disease](#) (eg, rheumatoid arthritis) or a bodywide infection. Symptoms of some autoimmune disorders can include fever, mouth sores, and rash. Pain that develops in one joint may also be the first symptom of a disorder that eventually affects many joints (see also [Joint Pain: Many Joints](#)).

Common causes

At all ages, injury, infection, and crystals in the joint (often called crystal-induced arthritis) are the most common causes of sudden pain in a single joint.

Among **young adults**, the most common causes are:

- Injury (most common)
- [Infection](#) (often caused by [gonorrhea](#) that has spread throughout the body or bloodstream [disseminated gonococcal infection], particularly if the joint is warm and swollen)
- Inflammation (caused by, for example, [gout](#))

Among **older adults** who have not been injured, the most common causes are:

- [Osteoarthritis](#) (most common)
- [Crystal-induced arthritis](#) (gout or [calcium pyrophosphate arthritis](#))

The most dangerous cause at any age is [acute infectious arthritis](#). Infectious arthritis can damage structures inside the joint within hours, which can lead to permanent arthritis. Rapid treatment can minimize permanent damage and prevent sepsis and death.

Common causes of pain in a single joint are listed in table

[Some Causes and Features of Pain in a Single Joint](#)

Less common causes

Less common causes of pain in a single joint include destruction of part of the nearby bone caused by poor blood supply ([osteonecrosis](#)), [joint tumors](#) (such as [pigmented villonodular synovitis](#)), blood in the joint (hemarthrosis), and disorders that usually cause pain in more than one joint, such as [reactive arthritis](#).

Evaluation of Pain in a Single Joint

The following information can help people decide when a doctor's evaluation is needed and help them know what to expect during the evaluation.

Warning signs

In people with pain in a single joint, certain symptoms and characteristics are cause for concern and are more likely to require immediate treatment. They include:

- Sudden or severe pain
- Joint redness, warmth, swelling, or limitation of motion
- Fever
- Broken, red, warm, or tender skin near the joint
- Presence of a bleeding disorder, use of anticoagulants ("blood thinners," for example, warfarin), or abnormal blood hemoglobin (for example, sickle cell disease)
- Signs of sudden illness other than joint pain
- Possibility of a sexually transmitted infection (for instance, due to unprotected sex with a new partner)

When to see a doctor

People with warning signs should see a doctor right away. Doctors are better able to treat symptoms more rapidly and completely if treatment occurs early in certain disorders, including crystal-induced arthritis, hemarthrosis, and infectious arthritis. People without warning signs, particularly if the cause of pain is known (for example, if typical pain recurs in a joint affected by osteoarthritis or if pain occurs after a minor injury) and symptoms are mild, can wait a few days and see whether symptoms resolve before seeing a doctor.

What the doctor does

Doctors first ask questions about the person's symptoms and medical history. Doctors then do a physical examination. What they find during the history and physical examination often suggests a cause of the pain and the tests that may need to be done (see table [Some Causes and Features of Pain in a Single Joint](#))

Doctors ask about the following:

- When the pain started, how it has progressed, where it is located, and its severity
- What makes the pain better or worse (for example, movement, weight-bearing exercise, or rest)
- Previous injuries or previous joint pain
- Symptoms in other joints (such as swelling)

- Risk factors for sexually transmitted infections and Lyme disease
- Known disorders, particularly those that could cause or contribute to joint pain (such as osteoarthritis, gout, or sickle cell disease)

The physical examination focuses on the joints for signs of inflammation (including swelling, warmth, and rarely redness), tenderness, limitation of motion, and noises made when the joint moves (called [crepitus](#)). Doctors compare the affected joint with the unaffected joint on the opposite side of the body to look for any subtle changes. Doctors may also look for signs of infection elsewhere on the body, particularly on the skin and genitals.

Several findings from the history and examination give clues to the cause of joint pain:

- Based on the examination, doctors can usually tell whether the source of the pain is the joint or nearby structures. For example, if only one side of a joint seems abnormal, the source of the pain is probably outside of the joint.
- Based on the examination, doctors can usually tell whether fluid is in the joint.
- Inflammation that develops over hours is usually caused by crystal-induced arthritis, particularly if similar symptoms have occurred previously. Infectious arthritis is another major cause of acute arthritis.
- Fever is most often caused by infectious arthritis or crystal-induced arthritis.



Some Causes and Features of Pain in a Single Joint

Cause	Common Features*	Tests
Crystal-induced arthritis (gout and related disorders such as calcium pyrophosphate arthritis)	Sudden and severe pain, swelling, warmth, and decreased range of motion, particularly in the great toe, ankle, wrist, or knee Sometimes with redness of the skin Often prior similar episodes of pain that resolved with or without treatment	Withdrawal and testing of joint fluid (joint aspiration) to look for crystals Sometimes ultrasound, CT, or x-rays
Hemarthrosis (blood in the joint)†	Symptoms may be spontaneous or begin soon after an injury Usually in a person with a recent injury or a bleeding disorder	Withdrawal and testing of joint fluid (joint aspiration) Sometimes CT or MRI
Infectious arthritis (for example, a bacterial, fungal, or viral infection or tuberculosis)‡	Sudden and severe pain, swelling, warmth, and decreased range of motion Sometimes gradual	Withdrawal and testing of joint fluid (joint aspiration)
Injury, such as a fracture or abnormality inside the joint that interferes with joint motion (for example, abnormal	pain and swelling Symptoms begin immediately after injury Often swelling	X-rays Sometimes MRI Sometimes insertion of a viewing scope into the joint (arthroscopy)



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